

The District AI Pilot Checklist

A 90-day map for running your first AI pilot, without betting the district on it.

One small pilot, run well, tells you more than a year of vendor demos. This is the map: pick one use case, protect student data, run it for real, and measure whether it actually helped.

How to use this checklist

Before you scale AI across a district, run one small pilot that proves it works. Work through these four sections in order. Each one has eight checkboxes in plain language. Nothing here requires a technical background.

This is useful whether or not you ever work with me. If you get to the end and want a second set of eyes, the last page tells you how to reach me.

1. Pick the use case

Start narrow. The fastest way to kill an AI pilot is to aim it at everything at once.

- ☐ Name one specific, recurring task that eats staff time. Not "use AI," an actual task.
- ☐ Choose a use case with a clear owner who feels the pain daily.
- ☐ Keep the first pilot to low-stakes, non-instructional work.
- ☐ Make sure every output has a human reviewer before it reaches a student or family.
- ☐ Estimate the hours the task costs your team each week, so you have a baseline.
- ☐ Confirm the use case is small enough to test in 90 days, not a district-wide rollout.
- ☐ Get one administrator who will champion it and clear roadblocks.
- ☐ Write the pilot goal in one sentence anyone on the team can repeat.

2. Vet for FERPA

Student data is the line you do not cross. Settle this before anyone logs in.

- ☐ Decide whether the tool will touch any personally identifiable student information.
- ☐ If it touches PII, route it through data privacy or legal review before you start.
- ☐ Check the vendor's data processing agreement, and confirm they will sign one.
- ☐ Verify the tool does not train its models on your data by default.
- ☐ Confirm where the data is stored and who can access it.
- ☐ Decide whether you can run the pilot on de-identified or synthetic data instead.
- ☐ Document a clear answer to "what happens to the data when the pilot ends."
- ☐ Brief participating staff on what they can and cannot put into the tool.

3. Run the pilot

Small group, fixed window, real work. Keep a fallback so nobody gets stuck.

- ☐ Limit the pilot to one team or one building, not the whole district.
- ☐ Set a fixed start and end date, 60 to 90 days.
- ☐ Train the staff in one short, practical session, not a manual.
- ☐ Give people a simple way to report what worked and what broke.
- ☐ Check in weekly for the first month, then every other week.
- ☐ Keep a running log of fixes, surprises, and open questions.
- ☐ Protect a fallback: people can always do the task the old way if the tool fails.
- ☐ Name one person who owns the pilot day to day.

4. Measure outcomes

Decide before you start what "it worked" looks like, then hold the pilot to it.

- ☐ Compare time spent on the task before and after, against your baseline.
- ☐ Ask the staff whether it actually made their work easier.
- ☐ Track quality, not just speed: did the output hold up to a human review.
- ☐ Count how often staff chose the tool over the old way. That is your real adoption signal.
- ☐ Note any privacy or accuracy issues that came up, and how you handled them.
- ☐ Decide the verdict: scale it, keep it at the team level, or cut it.
- ☐ Write a one-page summary leadership can read in five minutes.
- ☐ If it worked, pick the next use case before the momentum fades.

At day 90, pick one

Scale it across more teams. **Keep it** at the department level where it is working. Or **cut it** and bank what you learned. All three are wins. The only loss is a pilot that never reaches a decision.

Want a second set of eyes?

If you would like help scoping the use case, running the pilot, or reading the results, I do this work with districts every week. No vendor BS, just practical help that fits your reality.

[Book a call](#)

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Dr. Chris Sanzeri spent 15 years in education leadership before founding Evalve Consulting. I help education organizations implement AI that actually works, and I build the custom tools and automations that save teams time.